

Poor Little Rich KODA

In the past, Madhu Koda has turned crisis into opportunity. His defiance in the face of the latest threat suggests he may still have a few aces lined up his sleeve.

MAHADEO SEN

By Amitabh Srivastava

As a teenager, Madhu Koda always wanted to join the army. But his dream eluded him despite being an ace shooter with an A certificate from the National Cadet Corps. Standing 5 ft four-and-a-half inches in his socks, he was too short to be a soldier. Eventually, this didn't deter him from becoming the fifth chief minister of Jharkhand from September 2006 through August 2008.

Indeed, the life and times of Koda have been a picture of contrasts and contradictions, which he appears to have milked to his benefit. Till now, that is. The 39-year-old politician faces charges of money laundering and hawala transactions, besides other related allegations. He has been able to create opportunity out of crisis situations while growing out of his humble origins to write a remarkable turnaround story. No wonder, he still seems confident of wriggling out of the current money laundering charges surrounding him. While Koda is seen at the centre of a Rs 4,000-crore scam, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) and Income Tax (IT) officials have nothing but a seizure of Rs 23.65 lakh and \$3,430 (Rs 1.65 lakh) to show as "breakthroughs".

Even this is not just Koda's money. According to an affidavit filed by the IT Department in the Jharkhand High Court, this is the consolidated amount



**KODA (CENTRE) AND WIFE GEETA
CAMPAIGNING FOR THE
ASSEMBLY POLLS IN JHARKHAND**

With Assembly polls on, the cases could be a double-edged sword for Koda.